

AI vs Humans: Fight!

NO THIS ISN'T AN OPINION PIECE ABOUT HOW HUMANS CAN KEEP THEIR JOBS WITH AI LOOMING. In an issue when you have Calum Chace already opining about that, all of us just shut up and listen. Page 56 for those who want to wait no more to read his article.

What I'm going to focus on is the areas of differences between humans and algorithms, or AI/ML. I don't think we're headed to either a Star Trek like society where things are all free, manufactured from thin air and no one wants for anything. Neither do I believe we're headed for an AI-caused holocaust that will wipe out the majority of humanity. Both of those extremes seem to ignore the fact that we have this thing called money that isn't going anywhere soon.

I don't think I'm informed enough to be siding with either the AI Capitalists or AI Communists (and everyone in between), who all seem to think they have the right idea for how future societies should be designed. However, my own interest in the subject has caused me to delve deeper into the differences between artificial and human intelligence.

The simplest example I can think of is to look at birds. Even the best human ornithologist will lose to an AI in a competition to identify bird species through pictures. The human ornithologist will have studied for years, or even decades, and still they will have to search their slow, tissue and blood filled brains, and struggle to identify a few of the species, for sure. An AI will use its superfast RAM and learnings from thousands of ornithologists and their images to identify bird species with probably more accuracy and definitely more speed than any human ornithologist.

Out in the wild, a human ornithologist is in their element – they can identify birds just by looking at nests, or hearing a distant bird call above the din of the forest, or by finding a single feather, even by looking at bird droppings! And let's not forget, you can teach a human toddler what all birds are by showing it a couple of real birds. You don't need to show her/him every bird species on the planet to know it's a bird. You don't need to make sure the bird is sitting in front of a background that is contrasting, a human just knows a bird when it comes across one, from very little information, instinctively.

And yes, I get it, detractors will claim it's only a matter of time before AI/ML can do all

of those things. And to that I have to say, no... not yet at least. It's quite possible that AI will never think like a human. Humans excel in the unpredictable environments of the real world, while AI excels in the predictive environment of the virtual. And that's ok!

And yes, there will be a hundred headlines from the past and future (even from us) that will scream about more human AI being developed, but those are usually orders of magnitude away from building an 'artificial human intelligence'.

There are many who don't think we should even be attempting this, because it's totally futile. Can you imagine having to send your algorithm to virtual therapy where it lies on a sofa of code and spills its heart out to an AI therapist about how it feels unloved by its human masters? As vegans love to point out, given how we treat animals, a sentient race of AIs are doomed to be slaves.

There's a joke about a specialist plumber who was called after a homeowner could not figure out how to unblock his drainage pipes, and had called several local plumbers who had also failed. Plumber came in, inspected the house for 2 minutes, tapped on a pipe with his hammer, and everything just immediately flushed out of the system. He asked for Rs 5000. The owner was livid. "Rs 5000 for a 2 minute job? I want a breakup of the charges." "Sure," said the plumber. "Rs 5 to tap with the hammer. Rs 4995 for knowing where to tap."

That's human intelligence in a nutshell. The ability to know instinctively what to do, where to look, how to troubleshoot, and although it's clichéd, to think out of the box.

Yes AI will take away a lot of software-enabled jobs, and immediately replace a lot of mundane and repetitive jobs. Humans will either be forced into jobs that are more outdoorsy and labour driven, or indoorsy where a very high level of human thinking is needed.

I don't think we need to worry too much though, because unless a new species of sentient robots is born who start earning salaries and paying tax, there is a massive incentive for governments of the world to keep people employed, occupied and relatively happy.

If they're stupid enough to not do that, history has enough lessons to teach them about what happens when you pi** off an entire country of humans... 



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